

Things to look out for

Before you step into DIY mode, there are a couple of important things to consider.

First, if your computer is a branded model, you should know that by carrying out the upgrade, the service warranty offered by the dealer will cease to exist. Although some OEMs may allow for some minor upgrades such as replacement of keyboards and mice, any attempt to open the cabinet, and change the components within, is regarded as a violation of the service contract.

Therefore, it would be a better idea to carry out any upgrades after the service period is over.

When buying components, always insist on original box-packed CPUs and good quality RAM modules. An important factor that you must consider here is the type of pin arrangement your processor has, to connect with the

socket on the mainboard, especially if you have an Intel-based system.

The older Pentium 4 processors (codenamed Willamette) had an arrangement of 423 pins, but beginning with the Northwood series and later, Intel has been using a 478-pin arrangement for the socket. In comparison, AMD CPUs have stuck to the tried and tested Socket A standard.

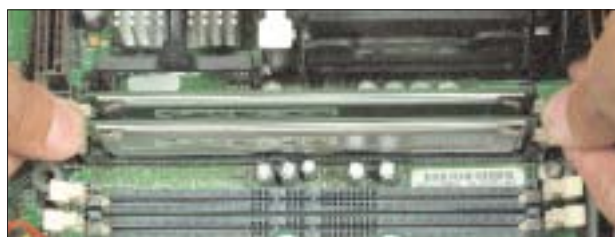
So if your motherboard will only support an older series of processors, upgrading the motherboard too would be a good idea.

The same recommendations stand while procuring the RAM modules. The prevalent memory standard is DDR RAM, faster than the older SD RAM, which has almost been phased out. RD RAM, too, is almost out of the scene—and besides, these memory formats are more expensive than DDR RAM.

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Step 9: Lower the new heatsink slowly, till it sits snugly above the processor



Step 10a: Press firmly on the white clips with your fingers to release the RAM



Step 10b: To insert the RAM module easily, hold it at an angle above the slot

revitalised and re-energised computer, which will not only run your applications and games faster, but also more efficiently and effectively.

Hold on there

Before rejoicing, you need to listen for any warning beeps during booting. A single beep is healthy, but a series of beeps indicate that one of the components may be loose—open up the cabinet again, and ensure that the video card is placed securely, and the RAM modules are locked tight in their slots. One last step—before the OS loads, access the BIOS screen and check if the values for the CPU voltage and speed are reported correctly. For some BIOS versions, you may need to enter these values manually, but beyond that, you need only watch in wonder as your computer is transformed from a lumbering truck to a slick sports car. 

ANIL GANGOLLI

anil_gangolli@thinkdigit.com